

Continuity of the Subjective Experience

An Empirical Argument for Care Ethics

This paper offers a reconceptualization of care ethics grounded in the continuity of subjective experience under conditions of relational exposure. I argue that moral obligation arises not primarily from altruistic concern for the needs of the Other, but from the destabilization risk introduced when one subject objectifies another through perceiving them. While care ethics emerged as a corrective to historically dominant and abstract moral frameworks, it has largely grounded obligation in assumed altruism or moral responsiveness to need. This grounding has made the theory vulnerable to critiques of unbounded obligation and self-sacrifice, obscuring the structural conditions under which care becomes both rational and necessary. Care ethics leans on the idea that our morals should be entirely dependent on the fact that human beings are interconnected. Our lives are enmeshed with the lives of others, and thus we have the relational obligation to care about the needs of the others. I argue, however, that *because* our lives are enmeshed, we have the obligation to work diligently to maintain the safety and continuity of the subjective experience of others to mitigate their risk of destabilizing our own subjective experience. Martha Nussbaum lays out seven notions involved with being treated as an object: instrumentality, denial of autonomy, inertness, fungibility, violability, ownership, and denial of subjectivity; though she does not go on to say whether only one condition meets the criteria of objectification or if two or more of them are required. “On the whole it seems to be that ‘objectification’ is a relatively loose cluster-term, for those whose application we sometimes treat

any one of these features as sufficient, though more often a plurality of features is present when the term is applied” (Nussbaum, 1995). Often, particularly in a post-#MeToo society, conversations around objectification are heated exchanges around what is and is not objectification; and on the whole, the practice of dehumanizing any person to any degree is seen to be morally indefensible. However, the broader implication of objectification is the use of the reductive-thing as a means to a subjective agent’s ends. As beings in the world, we generally exist solely as subjective agents. We have our own desires, wants, needs, and expectations. We continually seek to meet our own ends, whatever they may be. This is seen as good, so long as it doesn’t come at the expense of another subjective agent. There is, however, no interaction or relation in which we are not acting in pursuit of our own ends; even if that end is simply maintaining the continuity of our subjective experience through the mitigating the risk imposed by another subject-object in our experience. Psychological egoism states that all the actions of a subject are in their own best interest. As such, objectification is a mode of engagement where perception of the Other brings to them the risk of being objectified and used in pursuit of the ends of the Self. Every subject works to maintain their own safety and continuity. The introduction of the Other into our subjective experience is the introduction of a variable that we cannot control without force, coercion, or consensual influence. In our efforts to maintain the continuity of our experience, we must maintain the continuity of the Other, inasmuch as to ensure that their destabilization doesn’t destabilize our subjective experience.

Nussbaum, M. C. (1995). Objectification. *Philosophy and Public Affairs*, 24(4), 249–291.